What to measure

Week 5, Lecture 1 · Grow on X: From Zero to 10,000 Followers

Autumn 2026

What we'll cover

- Vanity metrics versus signal metrics: what the distinction actually means
- Impressions per follower as a content quality gauge
- Profile-visit-to-follow rate as the leading indicator of growth momentum
- Reading the analytics dashboard without confirming what you want to believe

By the end of this lecture you can open your analytics dashboard and pull out the two numbers that predict whether your account is growing or stalling.

Vanity metrics versus signal metrics

The vanity metric trap

- Follower count, total likes, and total impressions all feel meaningful
- They go up when things go well and down when things go wrong
- But they don't tell you why — and they can't tell you what to do next
- Ries (2009): "The only metrics that entrepreneurs should invest energy in collecting are those that help them make decisions."

A metric is only useful if acting on it would change your behavior.

What makes a metric a signal metric

- A signal metric shows cause and effect
- It is actionable: a change in the number implies a specific action
- It is tied to a stage of the funnel, not the whole funnel at once
- Welsh (2023): "The average creator never stops focusing on the top of their funnel. To build a real business, you have to move people from the top down to the bottom."

Examples of signal metrics for a creator: profile-visit-to-follow rate, link click rate, reply-to-impression ratio.

The funnel a creator actually runs

- **Impressions:** your content reached someone's feed
- **Engagements:** they paused, liked, replied, or clicked "show more"
- **Profile visits:** they cared enough to look at your page
- **Follows:** they decided you were worth a long-term subscription of attention

Each step is a conversion. A vanity metric lives at the top. Signal metrics live at the transitions between steps.

Chen (2018): "A rising curve tells you nothing predictive."

Impressions per follower

Why this ratio matters

- Raw impression counts are noisy: an account with 50,000 followers gets more impressions than one with 500, almost by definition
- Impressions per follower divides out audience size so you can compare across time and across accounts
- A ratio above 1.0x means a post reached more people than your follower count — the algorithm amplified it
- A ratio below 0.5x means the algorithm is suppressing your content or your followers are not engaging

Impressions per follower = total post impressions divided by follower count at the time of posting.

Reading the ratio

- Below 0.5x: the post did not earn distribution. Look at the hook and format.
- 0.5x to 1.0x: your followers saw it. Little to no algorithmic amplification.
- 1.0x to 3.0x: the algorithm pushed it to non-followers. A pattern worth understanding.
- Above 3.0x: a genuine spread event. Study what this post did that others did not.

Track the ratio per post, not as a monthly average. The average hides the variance.

Profile-visit-to-follow rate

The conversion rate you are not watching

- Every time someone visits your profile, they make a decision: follow or leave
- Profile-visit-to-follow rate = new followers divided by profile visits, expressed as a percentage
- Statweestics (2026): "The profile visit to follow rate is the strongest leading indicator of growth momentum."
- Benchmarks: 5% is healthy. 1% means your profile is not converting visitors.

This number separates a content problem from a profile problem.

Content problem versus profile problem

- If impressions per follower is high but profile-visit-to-follow rate is low: your content is getting seen, your profile is failing to close the deal
- Fix: rewrite the bio, update the pinned post, tighten the profile photo and header
- If impressions per follower is low but profile-visit-to-follow rate is high: your profile converts well but your content isn't reaching new people
- Fix: work on hooks, engage more, experiment with posting time

The two ratios diagnose two different problems.

Reading your dashboard without lying to yourself

Confirmation bias in self-analytics

- We remember posts that did well when we tried something new
- We forget the five posts that used the same tactic and flopped
- We pick the time window that shows growth and ignore the one that shows a plateau
- We compare our worst week to our best week to feel progress

Rachitsky (2021): "Which metric, if it were to increase today, would most accelerate my business' flywheel?" — if you can't answer that, you're measuring the wrong thing.

Three rules for honest reading

1. **Fix the window.** Pick one time period (28 days) and stick to it every week. Don't move the goalposts to make the numbers look better.
2. **Look at distributions, not totals.** Your top 3 posts may hide that the other 17 were flat. Total impressions obscures this. Look at per-post data.
3. **Write down the prediction before you run the experiment.** "I think this hook will outperform that one." Predictions force honesty about what you actually believe.

The two numbers to pull every week

Every week, before you plan next week's posts, calculate:

1. **Impressions per follower** for the previous week's posts (average and best)
2. **Profile-visit-to-follow rate** for the previous 28 days

Write them down. Date them. After six weeks you will have a trend line, not a single data point.

Take-aways

1. Vanity metrics feel good. Signal metrics drive decisions.
2. Impressions per follower is a per-post quality gauge that controls for audience size.
3. Profile-visit-to-follow rate is the leading indicator of growth momentum: it separates a content problem from a profile problem.
4. Confirmation bias distorts self-analytics. Fix the window, look at distributions, predict before you measure.
5. Two numbers, tracked weekly, are enough to navigate the dashboard without lying to yourself.

> "The average creator never stops focusing on the top of their funnel. To build a real business, you have to move people from the top down to the bottom."

Justin Welsh, *Metrics that Matter: Going Beyond Followers and Likes* (2023)

What's next

- **Section (this week):** Pull your last 30 days of X analytics. Classify your top 10 posts by hook, format, and topic.
- **Reading:** Week 5 reading — Analytics, experiments, and iteration at `/c/grow-on-x-26au/readings/wk05`
- **Lecture 2:** A/B testing posts and iterating
- **HW3 (Run your system):** due this week
- **HW4 (30-day growth experiment):** now out